Sacrifice

By Macey Baggett Wuesthoff

INTRODUCTION

This is the story of how the town of Grimshaw sold its soul to the Devil. What happened in Grimshaw could have happened—and still could happen—in virtually any small American town. Yet it happened in Grimshaw perhaps because the town was enduring extreme hardship at the time, which naturally causes weakness in man. Sacrifice by Macey Baggett Wuesthoff

A deep recession was sweeping the United States. That recession exceptionally devastated small towns like Grimshaw, which offered its peoples few industries and sources of income. The majority of the sparse sources of income in Grimshaw—factories, warehouses, restaurants, cafés, and various mom-and-pop businesses—closed their doors forever, leaving most of Grimshaw unemployed.

A rural town in the Deep South, Grimshaw was able to fall back on farming—until the recession was followed with a drought.

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Grimshaw, the smallest town in the affected region, the town with the fewest businesses still open, the town that relied most heavily on farming, was the town that suffered the most. Day after day, farmers lugged buckets of water to their thirsty fields, only to have their crops mock them by withering and browning into premature deaths.

Weeks extended into months. The drought and the recession went on…and on…and on…

With no end in sight to the tribulations, with the businesses gone, the land dying, and money and even food scarce, Grimshaw's population began to die out along with the economy and crops. Some of those who lived through it moved, a few abandoning their homes and property. Others couldn't leave due to lack of education, finances, personal strength, or various other inhibitors. Thus, they were stuck in Grimshaw to suffer and await the end of the drought, the recession, or themselves.

The hearts of those left in Grimshaw overflowed with dark, bitter pain. They were starving. They were

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thirsty. They were weary. They were angry. Most of all, they were desperate.

The most desperate among them was a farmer named John Weekly. Nine years before, when John and his high school sweetheart Gay were seventeen, they had dropped out of school to get married. Over the next seven years, they had three children. Together, the family lived a life that was humble yet full of love and happiness. That love and happiness ended during the latter part of John and Gay's eighth year of marriage, when Gay died due to complications in childbirth.
Gay had given birth to twin boys. That left John the widowed father of five at only twenty-five years old. Just weeks after Gay's death came the recession, followed by the drought. The factory where John worked closed, and the crops on his farm began to die. As a single parent, John found it harder and harder to care physically and financially for his children.

He had no living relatives to help him, and his friends and neighbors had too many troubles of their own to offer him aid. Like his own old tractor, worn and

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rusted from too much weather and use, John Weekly's spirit simply "broke down"—broke down worse than the spirit of anyone else in Grimshaw.
That is probably why he was chosen.

It happened on a Friday night, when John was in the modestly furnished bedroom he had shared with Gay. It was late, so John wore his usual sleepwear of a sleeveless undershirt and boxers. He looked at his reflection in the dusty, cracked mirror of the bureau across the room and shook his head. His skin was pale and his body gaunt from lack of nourishment, for he had been eating a little less so his children could have a little more. The hard times he'd been through that year had marked him with worry lines and patches of premature gray in his thinning, brown hair. Appalled by his own reflection, he switched on his bedside lamp and switched off his overhead light, trying not to face the shell of a man he had become.

John slumped onto the bed. On the nightstand to the bed's right were a folded piece of paper and a framed photo of Gay, smiling and beautiful, taken just

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before she died. John picked up Gay's photo and poured over it longingly. God, how he missed her, how he needed her now! In a way, though, he was glad she wasn't around to suffer through these hard times, to see how they had left him unable to support his own family. He dabbed his eyes with a handkerchief on the nightstand to stop the tears that threatened to seep through his lids.

That was it. Looking at Gay's photo and thinking about her hurt too much. John put the picture down, picked up the piece of paper, and unfolded it. Printed across the top were the words, "Mortgage Foreclosure, Final Notice." He shook his head again. So now he'd not only lost his wife, his job, and his crops, he was going to lose his home and land, too. Where would that leave his family?

"Daddy?"

John raised his eyes from the mortgage notice. His oldest daughter, eight-year-old Sarah, who was of age, stood gazing at him from outside the open doorway. Sarah was the only of the five children who had her late mother's blonde hair and blue eyes, but her facial

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features were almost identical of John's. John had once been quite proud of his daughter's face being so like his own. Now, seeing that similarity hurt him, for Sarah's countenance had recently taken on the pale, sickly color that he'd just observed in himself.

John asked, "What're you doing up, hon'?"

"I'm hungry," Sarah replied. "Everybody is. The twins are crying and pointing at their tummies and saying 'hun-ry, hun-ry.' And Gaylette and John Jr. are in my room now, saying they can't sleep 'cause their tummies are growling."

"Oh," John said distractedly, returning his attention to the mortgage notice. "There's a loaf of bread in the breadbox."

"Nuh-uh. That's gone."

"Gone?" John echoed.

"Yeah. We ate it all at dinner."

"Any crackers in the cabinet? Fruit in the fridge? Canned soup or vegetables in the pantry?"

Sarah answered each question with a shake of her head.

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"There's nothing in the house to eat." Her features brightened with an idea. "Hey, let's get some vegetables out of the garden!"

John shook his head sadly. "There ain't none. The drought's killed the whole push of them."

"Oh."

An awkward silence followed. Sarah lowered her eyes in the same defeated expression that John had also observed on his own face a minute before. It pained his soul. He tried to say something comforting. "I'll go into town tomorrow and get a few things. For now, why don't you have a glass of water, and get one for your brothers and sister too? It'll make y'all feel full."

His statement had the opposite effect. Sarah contorted her features and said resentfully, "I already did. We're still hungry!" Scowling, she pivoted and disappeared from the doorway.

John maintained his composure long enough to put the mortgage notice back on the nightstand, crawl under the covers, and switch off the lamp. But once he flipped over on his side, facing away from the door and the

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extinguished light, he allowed his tears to flow. He cried for his land, he cried for his children, he cried for his late wife. Mostly, though, he cried for himself.

"John."

At first, his name was spoken so faintly, so unexpectedly, that he assumed he had imagined it and just kept crying.

"John," it repeated, low and gravelly, with a hissing undertone.

The third time the voice sounded, John knew for sure it was real, because he heard it speak an entire sentence: "I can make it all better, John."

John's lids flew open, and he bolted upright in bed. "Who's there?" he called, groping for switch to his bedside lamp.

The voice came again, now angry. "Don't turn on that light!"

John dropped his hand but demanded, "Who are you?"

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Calm once more, it replied, "I am known by various names. The Prince of Darkness, the Antichrist, Lucifer, Beelzebub, Satan—"

"Aw, what a load of crap!" John sputtered. He reached for the lamp a second time.

The voice became deeper, louder, and more forceful than before. "I said, don't turn on that light!"

John searched the darkness. His heart began to pound. Just beyond the foot of his bed, in the corner between the bureau and the bedroom door, he saw two red eyes flashed on like lights. They glowed bright as fire. Down the middle of each eye, where a pupil should have been, there was instead a black, snake-like slit.

Now more afraid than he'd ever been in his life, John squeezed his own eyes shut so he could no longer see the bestial ones blazing back at him. He began murmuring, "Oh please, don't hurt me, please don't let him hurt me, Jesus—"

"Jesus?" the voice cut him off. It broke into loud, hysterical cackling. "What has He done for you lately?"

"Huh?" Awestruck, John opened his lids.

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"Brought you this endless recession? Given you this drought that has killed your crops and those of your friends and neighbors? Stolen your wife and the mother of your children? Left you and your family to starve to death? Fat lot of good He's been to you." It paused, and then, seeing that John was listening, repeated, "I can make it all better, John. I can give you back your home, your land, your job. I can make your crops grow once more, and ensure that you and your children never go hungry again. I can make it so that you, your friends—the entire town of Grimshaw—prosper."

It paused once more. John timidly whispered, "How?"

"Simple. I do something for you; you do something for me. I give you your lives back, and you give life back to me."

"I don't understand."

"You will repay me through sacrifice."

"Sacrifice? What sort of sacrifice?"

Sacrifices of blood."

"You mean, like animals or somethin'?"

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"Yes, sometimes goats and rams and such," the voice replied. "Other times, I will require the sacrifice of a child."

"WHAT?!" John cried. "We'd have to kill children?"

"Heed my words, John," it replied. "The whole town is perishing. What difference will a few children here and there make if it will save so many others from oblivion?"

John was reaching for the bedside light yet a third time when he realized that, sadly, this sounded like a logical proposition. He hesitated. "Children from where?"

"Children from Grimshaw only, of course. It would be foolish to do otherwise. If you venture outside town for your sacrifices, you will attract more attention and likely get caught."

John could scarcely believe the grotesque proposition that he was hearing. Nor that he was considering it. As his own stomach began to rumble,

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though, he heard himself ask, "Which ones? Just any of them?"

"Oh no, not just any.

Those with what some mortals have called 'angelic features'." Seeing that John didn't understand, it added, "Features like those of your daughter Sarah."

"No," John began to shake his head. "You can't mean you expect me to..."

"It would set a good example, a convincing example for the rest, if your own daughter were the first to be given to me."

John clenched his hands, ready to leap off the bed and pound the demon with his fists. "You ain't layin' a finger on my daughter!"

"No, I won't," it confirmed. "You will. You will sacrifice her to me."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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